

> **Drones and counter-drone technologies have a large role in future warfare. Today, there is a need to create a drone manufacturing ecosystem in India that is completely self-reliant**
>
> **RAJNATH SINGH**
> *Defence Minister*

ACROSS ALL MILITARY PLATFORMS BEING USED IN THE IRAN CONFLICT—A WAR OF MISSILE, BOMB AND DRONE STRIKES, counterstrikes and air defence—one of the clear winners is the humble, cheap UAV (unmanned aerial vehicle). Systems like Iran's Shahed-136 have shown how low-cost, mass-produced drones can penetrate even the most sophisticated air defence networks. Flying low and deployed in swarms or waves, such drones force defenders to use interceptor missiles that cost millions of dollars to shoot down UAVs worth a fraction of that amount. For example, a Shahed-136 kamikaze drone costs between $20,000 (Rs 18.8 lakhs) - $50,000 (Rs 47 lakhs), but each US Patriot missile interceptor costs around $4 million (Rs 37.6 crore). Many are neutralised, but the significant numbers that pierce missile defence shields are causing havoc. Crucially, they use pre-programmed navigation, with minimal reliance on real-time communication, making them more resilient in the face of sophisticated Electronic Warfare (EW) tools.

Taking a cue from the Iran war and the Ukraine conflict, where such drone tactics first made their mark, India is now focusing on mass production of indigenous, long-range strike drones. Like Shahed, the exemplar in this field, they are being designed to be cheap, scalable and deadly. A couple of Shahed-class programmes are currently underway, and the Ministry of Defence (MoD) may award a contract for this type to the industry before the end of 2026. India's policy push aims for industrial-scale production and secure supply chains by 2030. The goal: to build a "low cost, high impact" drone ecosystem delivering machines that can support swarm attacks in high-risk environments.

Speaking at the recent National Defence Industries Conclave, defence minister Rajnath Singh said, "We clearly see that drones and counter-drone technologies have a huge role in